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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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In ‘despair,’ Venezuelan migrants leave U.S.

Businesses and homes are empty as Biden-era protected status expires

BY MARÍA LUISA PAÚL

Carlos Rodríguez had finally begun to feel at home in the United States. He’d fled Venezuela in 2018 and spent the last six years building a future in Miami. He saved money with the dream of putting a down payment on a small house, adopted a dog after his first promotion and was quietly planning how to propose to his girlfriend.

But on Thursday night, the faint smell of coffee lingered in his apartment as he folded the last kitchen towel into a box — taking apart, piece by piece, the life he had worked so hard to create. The next day, he’d be giving his dog to the neighbors, ending his two-year relationship and boarding a flight to Spain.

“Not because I want to,” Rodríguez said, “but because I’m being forced out — again.”

Rodríguez, 30, is among the more than 600,000 Venezuelans who have, as of Friday, lost temporary protected status, or TPS — a designation that shielded them from deportation and allowed many to work and live in the United States. Overnight, some lost the jobs they’d held for years; others closed shops, walked away from leases and left homes standing empty. Many have also lost their licenses, health insurance and access to routine care.

The decision to revoke the protection triggered what Venezuelan American activist Adelys Ferro called “the largest mass illegalization of a group in this country’s history.” And it comes at a time when President Donald Trump is sinking alleged Venezuelan drug boats and gathering U.S. forces in the region, raising the possibility of land strikes.

“These are people who did everything by the book, paid taxes, had no criminal records, opened businesses and contributed to their communities,” Ferro said. “Now from one day to the other they’re subject to deportation and have become collateral damage in this cruel, unjust and inhumane political game.”

Across the country, the calculus **VENEZUELA ON A18**

Opposition: Maduro opponents pin hopes on Trump for change. **A19**



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

AMERICA AT 250

In the summer of 1774, Thomas Jefferson retreated to Monticello and wrote a secret plea meant to avert disputes with the British — a document that instead helped set America on the path to independence. As the nation prepares to celebrate the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence over the next year, The Washington Post examines Jefferson’s role, the document’s world-changing impact, the paradox of enslavement and the story behind the doctoring of words in the Jefferson Memorial.

48-PAGE SPECIAL INSIDE, SECTION W

Analysis of footage reveals Trump seeming to fight sleep

White House denies he dozed off, but clips show telltale signs of fatigue

BY DAN DIAMOND AND JM RIEGER

President Donald Trump hosted one of the more attention-grabbing press events of his term in the Oval Office this past week, announcing price cuts for weight-loss drugs, only to be interrupted when one of the attendees collapsed in a faint.

Before that dramatic turn of events, however, Trump appeared to struggle to stay awake as his health secretary, Robert F.

Kennedy Jr., and two other deputies took turns explaining the announcement. Clips of the scene have circulated widely on social media and drawn heavy criticism from Democrats.

A Washington Post analysis of multiple video feeds found that Trump spent nearly 20 minutes apparently battling to keep his eyes open at the Thursday event. It was a seemingly stark illustration of the strain of the presidency on a 79-year-old who typically keeps a vigorous travel schedule that even his aides say they struggle to keep up with — and who has revealed in calling his predecessor “Sleepy Joe” Biden.

Sitting behind the Resolute Desk on Thursday, the president displayed a constellation of **SEE TRUMP ON A2**

Far-right firebrand is driving wedge through MAGA ranks

Resurgence of onetime pariah Nick Fuentes sets off bitter GOP infighting

BY WILL OREMUS

Four years ago, Nick Fuentes was unwelcome pretty much everywhere. The young far-right influencer was barred from nearly every social media platform and an array of payment processors, either for violating hate speech policies or for encouraging rioters to storm the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021. A 2022 documentary by a sympathetic filmmaker called him “the most canceled man in America.”

Now a person who once called Adolf Hitler “awesome” has more than 1 million followers on Elon Musk’s X. He recently recorded a cordial interview with Tucker Carlson that more than 5 million people have watched. And he finds himself a central figure in an online battle over the future of the American conservative movement.

The resurgence of the 27-year-old Fuentes, who has argued that immigrants and “organized Jewry” are conspiring to extinguish the white race, has set off bitter infighting among conservative influencers over whether he should be tolerated or de-

SEE FUENTES ON A8

2028 field: Ranking the potential GOP presidential contenders. **A11**

Trump: Give ACA subsidies to people

URGES A PIVOT FROM PAYING INSURERS

Aims to press Democrats on ending the shutdown

BY DAN DIAMOND, MATTHEW CHOI AND MAEGAN VAZQUEZ

President Donald Trump on Saturday urged Senate Republicans to redirect funding for Affordable Care Act subsidies away from health insurers and toward average Americans, his latest gambit to pressure Democrats as a government shutdown snarls air traffic, leaves food stamp benefits in limbo and furloughs roughly 650,000 federal workers.

The Senate remained at an impasse on Saturday, a day after Republicans rejected a Democratic proposal that would have extended soon-to-expire ACA subsidies — a key sticking point in negotiations — for a year while reopening the government.

Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-South Dakota) said he would keep the chamber in session until there is an agreement to reopen the government. He continued to insist that any action to address health care costs, including Trump’s proposal, would have to be after the Senate resumes funding.

Trump’s demand to send funds directly to Americans, which would require an act of Congress, met immediate resistance from some Democrats and would face serious legislative headwinds given lawmakers’ inability to reach consensus on much smaller changes to the health law.

Trump, in several Truth Social posts Saturday, renewed his criticism of the health law, commonly known as Obamacare, when offering his proposal.

“I am recommending to Senate Republicans that the Hundreds of Billions of Dollars currently being sent to money sucking Insurance Companies in order to save the bad Healthcare provided by ObamaCare, BE SENT DIRECTLY TO THE PEOPLE SO THAT THEY CAN PURCHASE THEIR OWN, MUCH BETTER, HEALTHCARE, and have money left over,” Trump wrote.

SEE SHUTDOWN ON A4

Blue wave: Democrats also swept elections in lower-profile races. **A4**

FAA says MD-11 planes must be inspected after fatal crash

UPS, FedEx had already grounded fleets after Boeing recommendation

BY VICTORIA BISSET AND KYLE REMPFER

The cockpit voice recorder from the UPS cargo plane that crashed in Louisville on Tuesday captured the sound of a “repeating bell” in the final seconds before the aircraft crashed, aviation authorities said.

“During this time, the crew engaged in efforts to attempt to control the aircraft before the crash,” National Transportation Safety Board member Todd Inman told reporters. The crash of the MD-11 plane killed at least 14 people and sparked a large fireball as the air-

craft hit two businesses.

The Federal Aviation Administration said Saturday afternoon that it was issuing an emergency airworthiness directive prohibiting operators from flying MD-11s, and the MD-11F variant of the airplane, “until they perform certain inspections and take any necessary corrective actions.”

The order applies to more than 100 U.S.-registered aircraft, the FAA said.

By Saturday morning, UPS and FedEx had already grounded dozens of MD-11 aircraft, as Boeing said it had recommended to “operators of the MD-11 Freighter that they suspend flight operations while additional engineering analysis is performed.”

FedEx, which has 28 MD-11s in operation, said it made the decision “out of an abundance of caution” while it conducted a safety **SEE CRASH ON A8**



ILLUSTRATION BY DEENA SO’OTEH/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Ever-rising sleep apnea claims cost VA billions

Efforts to modernize the benefits system and cut back on payments for the condition have stalled

BY LISA REIN, CRAIG WHITLOCK AND CAITLIN GILBERT

Over decades, the government has spent billions on disability payments for veterans with sleep apnea, a common condition that interrupts breathing during sleep and causes fatigue. In early 2022, officials were determined to pare that back.

Medical advances mean most apnea sufferers now have few or no symptoms and can hold jobs. So Denis McDonough, then the secretary of the Department of Veterans Affairs, announced a proposal to change the benefits system to reflect the new reality, and — going forward — slash monthly checks for many veter-

ans.

It went nowhere.

The episode was the latest failed attempt to rein in the \$193 billion disability program in the era of modern medicine. Even as once-debilitating ailments become manageable for most patients, the government has repeatedly backed away from updates that would anger veterans and their supporters, The Washington Post found.

Approved sleep apnea claims have exploded, growing more than elevenfold from 2009 to 2024, VA data shows. Last year, about 660,000 veterans collected disability benefits for sleep apnea — up from 57,000 in 2009.

It’s created “a catch-22 all the **SEE APNEA ON A6**

SPORTS

The next Tom Brady? No. The Patriots’ Drake Maye is a different breed. **B1**

BUSINESS

Farming and mining are among the careers that are nearly extinct. **B11**



ARTS & STYLE

How A-ha’s hit “Take on Me” became an eternal global earworm.

METRO

Beyond Spanberger, women fuel a leftward shift in Virginia. **B18**



TRAVEL

Urban parks, nestled in U.S. cities, offer green spaces worthy of a trip.

BOOK WORLD

Novelist David Baldacci’s new initiative aims to address toxic discourse.

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